History (and a Dash of Hollywood)

By Seth Kramer

CHARACTERS: *2 men or 2 women*

(Lights up. CAESAR walks around a large desk, HARRISON sits across from him. There are numerous pads of paper and pens.)

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *You think Americans don't care about history?*
ACTOR 2: *Think again. – From Ben Hur to Shindler's List – Awards were granted and the American public scrambled to see history unfold on the big screen.*
ACTOR 1: *Popular films increase interest in history and contain much accurate information,*
ACTOR 2: *But producers of these films often take liberties with facts to tell a more entertaining story.*
ACTOR 1: *In fact, movies based on actual history tend to be a mixed bag.*
ACTOR 2: *Transforming complicated events and people into entertaining films is never easy*
ACTOR 1: *But when is it justified to sacrifice historical facts for entertainment value?*
ACTOR 2: *You see . . . The road to Hell is paved with good intentions . . .*
ACTOR 1: *Especially when money is involved.*
ACTOR 2: *History*
ACTOR 1: *(and a Dash of Hollywood)*
TOGETHER: *by Seth Kramer*

CAESAR: So it's a script idea?

HARRISON: Sure.

CAESAR: Some new project?

HARRISON: That's right.

CAESAR: Talk to me.

HARRISON: OK. Benjamin Franklin. He's an inventor. He's a brilliant mind. A founding father.

CAESAR: OK.

HARRISON: We follow his life. His accomplishments.

CAESAR: He's our good guy?

HARRISON: Good guy?

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CAESAR: Yeah, our hero. He does something. He fights in the revolutionary war. He saves the colony somehow? Rides a horse through towns: "The British are coming, the British are coming!" Something, right?

HARRISON: Well . . .

CAESAR: Talk to me.

HARRISON: That's not exactly right.

CAESAR: No?

HARRISON: Paul Revere made that ride.

CAESAR: Oh, well, he . . . something, what? The battle of Bunker Hill, the Boston Tea Party? What?

HARRISON: Benjamin Franklin was an inventor.

CAESAR: An inventor?

HARRISON: Yes, an inventor . . . one of the times· most respected thinkers.

CAESAR: I see. And you want to . . . what? Make a movie about this? About him and his ... thinking?

HARRISON: He had a very high IQ.

CAESAR: What's the movie'? What's the story?

HARRISON: Well, I told you, Benjamin Franklin was an inventor. He was one of our founding fathers. It could be a very educational film. Put people in touch with their roots.

CAESAR: No.

HARRISON: No?

CAESAR: No. There is no such thing as an "Educational Film." Not in this day and age. Not with fifteen million dollar budgets on the small projects. Do you want to make money? Huh? You do remember money, don't you? You want to educate, get a job at PBS. Go work for Sesame Street. Become a teacher!

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HARRISON: I . . .

CAESAR: If you want to educate.

HARRISON: Are you saying that film can't educate?

CAESAR: Look... LOOK. This is movies, all right? You and me, we make movies. If someone looks at one of my flicks in twenty or thirty years and says it's ART or that they found it educational then they can give me a fuckin' plaque. That's of course assuming I'm still alive. But right now-TODAY- I want to kick something out. I want something I can walk into a studio with, sit down across from some cock-sucking vulture, and SELL. S-E-L-L.

HARRISON: You don't think historical movies can sell?

CAESAR: Let's just say I'm skeptical.

HARRISON: What about westerns? What about war movies? Don't they sell?

CAESAR: *(long pause)* Tell me THE STORY.

HARRISON: The story?

CAESAR: Let's work with it. Let's see what we can piece together.

HARRISON: I don't see how you can piece together histo-

CAESAR: Trust me.

HARRISON: *(pause)* OK.

CAESAR: Shoot.

HARRISON: Benjamin Franklin, he's one of the times' most prominent . . .

CAESAR: Inventor, founding father, thinker, Jesus, are you repetitive. Got it, we've done this before. Start the story. Start with . . . What?

HARRISON: Oh, I see . . . OK, Franklin is . . .

CAESAR: BEN. Call him Ben.

HARRISON: OK, Ben. Ben is a young man, he grows up in a prominent colonial family. He spends a great deal of his time reading and studying.

CAESAR: He's a loner.

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HARRISON: I suppose.

CAESAR: He's angry all the time. He broods. A handsome, misunderstood loner.

HARRISON: Actually . . .

CAESAR: A young Brando-type.

HARRISON: No, actually . . .

CAESAR: James Dean?

HARRISON: Actually, he had a weight problem his whole life. He also had a mild form of asthma.

CAESAR: Oh, well that's gripping. We may have to take a few liberties. Change a bit here, change a bit there. BEN is our hero. We have to make him seem like a HERO, kapeesh?

HARRISON: I just think historical accuracy . . .

CAESAR: You want historical accuracy, write a book! We have two hours to tell a story, reality needs to be condensed. Let's move on.

HARRISON: Um . . .

CAESAR: Ben is young. He has a problem with authority. Where do we go from here?

HARRISON: Well, he's an inventor.

CAESAR: And?

HARRISON: And he . . .

CAESAR: What?

HARRISON: He invents the first . . .

CAESAR: Remember THINK FILM.

HARRISON: The first *(pause.)* Time machine?

CAESAR: Time machine?

HARRISON: Time machine. Hey, you said think film.

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CAESAR: No. No. That's good. I like that. Time machine. Boy, once you get moving you don't screw around.

HARRISON: Anyway, he invents it.

CAESAR: Wait.

HARRISON: What?

CAESAR: God just spoke to me! He FINDS it!

HARRISON: FINDS it? He's an inventor! What's the point of having him be an inventor unless he can . . .

CAESAR: No. Wait. Wait. It finds him. The time machine comes to him. That's the story. That's what we need. A hook. Let's say, in the future, this guy, this scientist . . .

HARRISON: Scientist?

CAESAR: Indiana Jones type.

HARRISON: OK.

CAESAR: This Indiana Jones type, he discovers a plot that your basic, everyday, evil genius has hatched . . .

HARRISON: Wait?

CAESAR: What?

HARRISON: Saddam Hussein. Let's make the evil genius a Saddam Hussein type.

CAESAR: Now you're thinking! Saddam is very vogue as far as villains go this year. OK, what's the plot?

HARRISON: Well, OK. Let's say . . . Saddam is going to back in time to ... TO ASSASSINATE Franklin.

CAESAR: Ben.

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HARRISON: Right, Ben. Saddam wants to stop America from ever happening by killing off BEN. Now our hero, our Indiana Jones type, has to go back in time and prevent this.

CAESAR: It's a buddy-buddy film.

HARRISON: Those sell, right?

CAESAR: Like blue jeans in Russia. Ben and Indiana fight off a horde of Middle-Eastern-type assassins dressed up like redcoats.

HARRISON: Along the way maybe this Indiana guy can fall in love?

CAESAR: Sure, it's a romance across time.

HARRISON: Very Romeo and Juliet.

CAESAR: Only nobody dies. I love it, LOVE IT! Go on.

HARRISON: Our Indiana Jones hero has to deal with other stuff too. No plumbing, no TV, no microwaves. Stuff like that.

CAESAR: A comment on modem society. Very interesting. What else?

HARRISON: He brings his Walkman with him.

CAESAR: What?

HARRISON: It gets stolen.

CAESAR: Where you goin' with this?

HARRISON: *(lost in his own world)* Some little kid takes it. Some kid that in the future is going to be very important. A young Thomas Jefferson! So now our hero, Indiana, has to retrieve it without affecting the kid's life too much, or he could seriously screw up the Space-time continuum.

CAESAR: Space-time con-what-uum?

HARRISON: It's a Star Trek term. People that are into time travel will eat that up.

CAESAR: Well, that's all right then.

HARRISON: So what do you think?

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CAESAR: Honestly? It's *crap*-BUT-conservatively here, I'm thinking, a million bucks.

HARRISON: A cool million.

CAESAR: Hey. It's a movie, man.

HARRISON: History.

CAESAR: Ya got to love it, you know what I mean?

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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